

Writing a script

VOICE-OVERS AND DRAMATIC SCRIPTS HAVE TO BE EFFECTIVE WHEN READ ALOUD.

The words in a script are spoken to an audience, so they have to be easy to understand. Scripts also need to be laid out in specific ways, and include instructions for the people involved.

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Voice-overs

A voice-over is the audio commentary that accompanies a short video, such as a documentary, an advertisement, or a nonprofit campaign film. A useful way to lay out a voice-over script is to use a table with columns.

Easy listening

A voice-over needs to be written in simple language so that listeners will understand what is said immediately. They can't go back and read sections again. Using simple sentences and words will also make a script easy for narrators to read, so they won't stumble over their words.

This column describes the images that will be shown on screen.

Each column shows different elements of a voice-over, plotted against time, in minutes.

Time	Images	Words	Sound effects
0:00	Beautiful and colorful images of rainforest plants and wildlife	The Amazon rainforest has the largest collection of plant and animal species in the world. Millions of weird and wonderful living things call this their home.	Peaceful jungle sounds
0:15	Shocking scene of deforestation	But for how long will this rainforest survive?	Silence
0:20	Zoom over deforestation	Silence	Silence

Words and pictures

In a voice-over script, the words need to relate to the images on screen, giving extra information about them. However, it is often effective to include occasional silences, so the audience can focus on and absorb what they see.